INVESTIGATOR'S FOLDER

Murder

All clues recovered and evidence documents collected during the investigation. Review every detail — the truth hides in the smallest things.

PART ONE

Clues

Bloodied Marble Paperweight

PHYSICAL EVIDENCE | CRITICAL

A heavy marble paperweight with blood on it, found on the floor near Charles Whitmore's body. It has Vivian Cross's fingerprints on it.

Found at: Top Floor Office, near the body

Hint: The weapon bears the killer's prints.

Missing Wallet and Watch

PHYSICAL EVIDENCE | CRITICAL

Charles's wallet and watch are missing from his person. They are later found in Vivian Cross's office safe, along with financial documents showing large unexplained deposits.

Found at: Vivian Cross's office safe

Hint: The stolen goods lead to the killer's safe.

Whiskey Bottle with Fingerprints

PHYSICAL EVIDENCE | CRITICAL

A half-empty bottle of Charles's favorite whiskey on the desk, with only Charles's and Vivian's fingerprints on it.

Found at: Top Floor Office, on the desk

Hint: The bottle proves she was there.

Witness Sighting of Vivian

TESTIMONY | CRITICAL

A guest saw Vivian Cross leaving the top floor around 23:15, looking flustered and smoothing her dress.

Found at: Grand Ballroom

Hint: A guest's observation breaks her alibi.

Locked Office Door

OBSERVATION | MAJOR

The office door was locked from the outside. Only Vivian Cross and Charles Whitmore had keys to the office.

Found at: Top Floor Office

Hint: The locked door points to someone with a key.

Vivian's Financial Records

DOCUMENT | CRITICAL

Financial records in Vivian's office show large unexplained deposits over several years, indicating embezzlement.

Found at: Vivian Cross's office

Hint: The records reveal a hidden motive.

James's Argument with Charles

TESTIMONY | MAJOR

James Whitmore was seen arguing with his father earlier in the evening. He has a gambling addiction and owes money to dangerous people.

Found at: Grand Ballroom

Hint: The son's debts and argument are a distraction.

Elena Near the Elevator

TESTIMONY | MINOR

Elena Rodriguez was seen near the elevator around 23:00, looking nervous. She is secretly in love with James and has been feeding him information.

Found at: Near the elevator

Hint: The assistant's nervousness is a red herring.

Marcus Leaving the Ballroom

TESTIMONY | MAJOR

Marcus Reed was seen leaving the ballroom around 22:45. He is a business rival who has threatened Charles and planned a hostile takeover.

Found at: Grand Ballroom

Hint: The rival's absence is suspicious but innocent.

Sophia's Blackmail Photos

PHYSICAL EVIDENCE | MAJOR

Blackmail photos of Charles with Sophia Laurent were found in her room. She had a brief affair with Charles and was blackmailing him.

Found at: Sophia Laurent's suite

Hint: The actress's blackmail scheme is a diversion.

Chef Antonio Leaving Kitchen

TESTIMONY | MINOR

Chef Antonio Moretti was seen leaving the kitchen around 23:00. He has been stealing expensive ingredients and Charles was about to fire him.

Found at: Kitchen area

Hint: The chef's theft is unrelated to the murder.

Vivian's Broken Alibi

TESTIMONY | CRITICAL

A guest reveals she saw Vivian coming from the elevator, not the restroom, around 23:15. This contradicts Vivian's claim of being in the restroom from 23:00 to 23:30.

Found at: Grand Ballroom

Hint: A guest's testimony shatters her alibi.

Planted Gambling Debts

PHYSICAL EVIDENCE | MAJOR

James's gambling debts were found in Charles's office, but the evidence appears to be planted, with no fingerprints and placed conspicuously.

Found at: Top Floor Office

Hint: The planted evidence points to a setup.

Vivian's Flustered Demeanor

OBSERVATION | MINOR

Vivian was seen smoothing her dress and looking flustered when she returned to the party, a nervous habit she has when under stress.

Found at: Grand Ballroom

Hint: Her nervous habit betrays her.

PART TWO

Evidence Documents

SECURITY REPORT — SECURITY REPORT: TOP FLOOR ACCESS LOG

GRAND MAJESTIC HOTEL - SECURITY LOG
Date: December 31, 2023

TOP FLOOR ACCESS (PENTHOUSE/OFFICE)

22:55 - Charles Whitmore (Owner) enters via private elevator.
23:00 - Vivian Cross (Hotel Manager) enters via private elevator, carrying a bottle.
23:15 - Vivian Cross exits via private elevator, appearing hurried.
23:30 - No further access until 00:30 when James Whitmore and security respond to locked door.

NOTE: The private elevator requires a key card. Only Charles Whitmore, Vivian Cross, and the Head of Security possess key cards. The security desk was unmanned from 22:50 to 23:20 due to a disturbance in the lobby (a guest's dog).

Log recorded by: Security Officer M. Reynolds

WITNESS STATEMENT — WITNESS STATEMENT: CLARA WINSTON

I, Clara Winston, guest at the Grand Majestic Hotel, state the following:

At approximately 22:30, I was near the bar in the Grand Ballroom. I saw Vivian Cross and Charles Whitmore talking. Charles looked very angry and was speaking in a low, intense voice. Vivian seemed to be trying to calm him down. I heard Charles say, 'You think I wouldn't find out? You're done.' Vivian replied, 'Please, Charles, not here. We can discuss this privately.'

Later, around 23:15, I was waiting for the elevator on the ground floor. When the doors opened, Vivian Cross stepped out. She looked flustered and was smoothing down her dress. She didn't see me. She quickly walked back toward the ballroom.

I thought it was odd because she had told me earlier she was going to the restroom, but the restroom is on the mezzanine, not the top floor.

Signed: Clara Winston

INVESTIGATION REPORT — INVESTIGATION REPORT: CRIME SCENE SUMMARY

CHICAGO POLICE DEPARTMENT - PRELIMINARY INVESTIGATION REPORT
Case #: 2024-001
Victim: Charles Whitmore, 58
Location: Top Floor Office, Grand Majestic Hotel
Date: January 1, 2024

SUMMARY:
Victim found at 00:35 by son, James Whitmore, after forcing entry with master key. Door was locked from outside. Victim was face down near desk, cause of death blunt force trauma to back of head. Weapon: marble paperweight found on floor, covered in blood. Wallet and watch missing from victim's person.

EVIDENCE COLLECTED:
- Marble paperweight with blood and fingerprints (later matched to Vivian Cross)
- Half-empty whiskey bottle on desk, fingerprints only Charles Whitmore and Vivian Cross
- No signs of forced entry
- Office key card log shows Vivian Cross entered at 23:00 and exited at 23:15
- Victim's wallet and watch later found in Vivian Cross's office safe, along with financial documents indicating embezzlement
- Planted gambling debts in victim's desk drawer, no fingerprints

WITNESS STATEMENTS:
- Clara Winston saw Vivian Cross exiting elevator from top floor at 23:15, flustered.
- Several guests saw Vivian Cross in ballroom after 23:30.
- James Whitmore discovered body at 00:35.

PRELIMINARY CONCLUSION:
Homicide. Primary suspect: Vivian Cross. Motive: embezzlement discovered by victim. Means: access to office and weapon. Opportunity: present at time of death. Alibi: disproven by witness and key card log.

LETTER — LETTER FROM CHARLES WHITMORE TO VIVIAN CROSS

Dear Vivian,

I am writing this to inform you that I have discovered discrepancies in the hotel's financial records. Over the past three years, substantial amounts have been diverted to an offshore account in your name. I have consulted with our auditors and legal counsel. This is embezzlement, plain and simple.

I have considered our long working relationship, but I cannot overlook this. I will be terminating your employment effective immediately and will be pressing charges. I expect your resignation letter by tomorrow morning.

I suggest you enjoy tonight's gala, as it will be your last as an employee of the Grand Majestic.

Sincerely,
Charles Whitmore

P.S. I have not yet informed the board, but I will do so if you do not cooperate.

DIARY ENTRY — DIARY ENTRY: VIVIAN CROSS

December 31, 2023

He knows. I saw it in his eyes tonight. Charles knows about the money. I thought I had more time. He threatened to fire me and call the police. I can't go to prison. I won't.

I have to fix this. I'll meet him in his office. I'll bring his favorite whiskey. I'll pretend to apologize, to make peace. He'll be off guard. Then I'll... I don't know. I just need to make him listen. Maybe I can convince him to give me a second chance.

But if he won't... I have no choice. It's him or me.

God forgive me.

RECEIPT — RECEIPT: LIQUOR STORE PURCHASE

GOLDEN SPIRITS LIQUOR STORE
Date: December 31, 2023
Time: 20:45

ITEM: Macallan 18-Year-Old Single Malt Scotch Whisky
PRICE: $350.00

CUSTOMER: Vivian Cross
PAYMENT: Credit Card ending in 4321

Thank you for your purchase!

RECORD — RECORD: VIVIAN CROSS'S OFFICE SAFE INVENTORY

GRAND MAJESTIC HOTEL - INTERNAL AUDIT
Date: January 1, 2024

SAFE INVENTORY - VIVIAN CROSS'S OFFICE

- Charles Whitmore's wallet (containing $500 cash, credit cards, ID)
- Charles Whitmore's Rolex watch (engraved 'C.W.')
- Financial documents:
  - Bank statements showing deposits totaling $1.2 million over 3 years
  - Offshore account details in Vivian Cross's name
  - Embezzlement ledger

NOTE: Safe was opened with Vivian Cross's key. Contents photographed and logged.

NEWSPAPER ARTICLE — NEWSPAPER ARTICLE: HOTEL HEIR'S GAMBLING DEBTS

CHICAGO TRIBUNE - BUSINESS SECTION
December 28, 2023

WHITMORE HEIR IN HOT WATER OVER GAMBLING DEBTS

Sources close to the family report that James Whitmore, son of hotel magnate Charles Whitmore, has accumulated significant gambling debts, allegedly owed to organized crime figures. The elder Whitmore has reportedly refused to bail out his son, leading to a strained relationship. James was overheard arguing with his father at a recent charity event, shouting, 'You'll regret this when you're gone!' The elder Whitmore's fortune is estimated at $200 million, which James stands to inherit.

PHOTOGRAPHIC EVIDENCE — PHOTOGRAPHIC EVIDENCE: CRIME SCENE

Photograph 1: Overview of office. Charles Whitmore's body lying face down near desk. Blood pooling from head wound.

Photograph 2: Close-up of marble paperweight on floor, bloodstained, with visible fingerprints.

Photograph 3: Whiskey bottle on desk, half-empty, two glasses present. One glass near victim's hand, one empty glass on side table.

Photograph 4: Desk drawer open, containing planted gambling debts (IOUs with James Whitmore's name).

Photograph 5: Office door lock, showing no signs of forced entry.

Photograph 6: Victim's wrist, showing tan line where watch was removed.

Photograph 7: Empty wallet on floor near body, but no cash or cards inside.

WITNESS STATEMENT — WITNESS STATEMENT: ELENA RODRIGUEZ

I, Elena Rodriguez, personal assistant to Charles Whitmore, state:

At around 23:00, I was near the elevator on the ground floor, waiting for James Whitmore. I was nervous because I had overheard Charles and Vivian arguing earlier, and I knew James was upset about his debts. I saw Vivian Cross come out of the private elevator at approximately 23:15. She was smoothing her dress and looked pale. She didn't see me. She walked quickly toward the ballroom.

I also saw James Whitmore in the ballroom around 23:20. He seemed anxious and was checking his phone.

I did not see anyone else go up to the top floor.

Signed: Elena Rodriguez